A POCKET GUIDE TO PANIC & ANXIETY

# When panic comes, *breathe slower than it.*

*Breath connects us all.*

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# I know *this place.*

One evening, lying in bed with my beloved, watching TV, a sharp pain stabbed through my chest. Within minutes it spread like a steel band tightening around my ribs. My heart hammered so hard I felt each beat in my throat. Cold sweat soaked my shirt, my hands trembled.

*"This is it,"* I thought. *"I'm having a heart attack."* Through gritted teeth I said: *"Maybe we should call an ambulance."*

Then came her steady voice: *"Wait. This feels familiar. Could it be a panic attack?"*

That simple question became my lifeline. Against every screaming instinct, I drew one slow breath through my nose. Held. Released, longer than the inhale. Again. And again. I rolled my neck slowly. The vise loosened, and gradually the storm began to subside.

> *"Panic is your body's false alarm: a fire alarm blaring when there is no fire."*

## What is happening *in your body*

- The brain's fear centre (amygdala) shouts **"danger!"** and adrenaline floods the body.
- Heart races, breath gets fast and high, you sweat and shake.
- Fast breathing lowers $CO_2$: dizziness, tingling hands, a tight chest.
- These sensations convince the mind the danger is real, and the loop spins faster.

It feels terrifying, but the wave usually peaks within about 10 minutes and then eases. **You're not broken. You're not in actual danger. This will pass.**

*Every panic wave rises, peaks and passes.*
*Your breath is the way through.*

# Breathe *with me.*

Follow the circle. In through the nose for 4, out softly through the mouth for 6.




**IN · 4**
through the nose

**OUT · 6**
soft, slow, longer

### SLOW, NOT BIG

Don't gulp air. Let each breath be soft and quiet.

### TOO MUCH?

Start with 3 in, 5 out. A gentle 4-count pause after the inhale is fine if easy.

### LIKE WARM SOUP

Exhale as if blowing gently on a spoonful of warm soup.

*A longer exhale is your body's natural brake. Practise it when you're calm, so it's there when you need it.*

# Seven steps *through the wave*

Go slowly. You don't need all of them. One is enough to begin.

1 **Name it**

Put a hand on your heart and tell yourself what this is.

"This is my body's alarm. I am safe. This will pass."

2 **Feel your feet**

Sit down if you can. Press your feet into the floor. Let the chair or the ground hold your weight.

3 **Breathe slower than your panic**

In through the nose for **4**, out softly for **6**. Use the circle on page 3.

4 **Hum on the exhale**

A soft "mmmm" or a low "voooo". The vibration soothes and lengthens the out-breath.

5 **Come back to the room: 5-4-3-2-1**

Name 5 things you see, 4 you can touch, 3 you hear, 2 you smell, 1 you taste.

6 **Cool the body**

Splash cold water on your face or hold an ice cube or a cold glass. Cold can help the heart slow down.

7 **Soften and let it move**

Slowly roll your neck, drop your shoulders, soften your jaw. If your body wants to tremble, let it. Shaking is a natural way to release survival energy.

**Don't fight the wave.** Let the sensations rise and fall, and keep coming back to the long exhale. Each time you ride one out, your body learns it can.

POCKET CARD

## When panic comes

**1 · Name it.** "This is my body's alarm. This will pass."
**2 · Feet** on the floor.
**3 · Breathe** in 4 · out 6.
**4 · Hum** on the exhale.
**5 · 5-4-3-2-1:** see, touch, hear, smell, taste.
**6 · Cold** water on the face.
**7 · Soften,** let it move.

This wave will pass. Keep breathing.

*Breath connects us all.*

# Keep it *close.*

Screenshot this card and save it on your phone, or print and cut it out for your wallet. In a hard moment, you won't need to think. Just follow the card.

## Right after

- Rest. Sip water, wrap up warm, eat something light.
- Be kind to yourself. Tiredness and tears are normal.
- Write a few lines: when it came, what helped.
- Notice one thing that helped, so you can return to it next time.

## Day to day

- **Practise when calm:** 5 minutes of 4-in / 6-out a day.
- **Train your vagus nerve,** your body's calm-down highway: humming, singing, gargling water, a cool shower, time in nature.
- **Move** every day; even a 10-minute walk helps.
- **Go easy on caffeine and alcohol;** both can unsettle your stress response.
- **Reduce overstimulation:** fewer screens and notifications.
- **Rest before collapse.** Rest is a need, not a reward.

> *Healing isn't glamorous. The nervous system learns through repetition: small, gentle signals of safety, again and again, until the body believes them.*

# Holding space *for someone in panic*

Your calm is the most powerful tool in the room. Their nervous system will borrow yours.

## DO

- **Meet them first.** Kneel or sit at their level, with eye contact if they welcome it.
- **Stay close and steady.** Lower your voice, slow your own breath. Ask before touching.
- **Short, simple words:** *"You're safe. I'm here. This will pass."*
- **Breathe with them.** Count aloud: in 4, out 6.
- **Ground them:** feet on the floor, eyes open, name things in the room.

## IN A BREATHWORK SESSION

- Stop the active breathing. Bring them to sitting, eyes open, slow nose breath.
- Offer a blanket, water and a quiet corner.
- **Don't** say "calm down", argue with the fear, or rush them.
- Don't leave them alone until they feel settled. Check in later, and suggest follow-up support if needed.

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Bodyworker, breathwork facilitator and trainer in Biodynamic Breathwork & Trauma Release (BBTRS), co-founder of the Integral Body Institute. I left a career in engineering in 2008 to follow the body, the breath and trauma healing.

That night taught me panic is like a glitch in the body's software: frightening, but you can work with it. The next time panic tries to convince you you're dying, you'll know better. **You'll breathe through it, and you'll come out the other side.**

**nisarga8.com** · 21 days of gentle breath: **breathe.bodyawareness.ee**

*With heartfelt compassion and dedication, Nisarga*

*Breath connects us all.*

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